support Sri Olaganathan [VOC's first son], his brother & mother by sending them every month regularly a certain amount that can be raised by us every month.'[76]

Handicapped by his incarceration, VOC did what he could as a man of honour and integrity. Even as he sought legal help, he communicated that, even though the debts may have become void due to limitation, he promised to repay them within two years of his release. He communicated this message to his lawyer. Apparently, the *vakalat* on his behalf, was to be submitted on 2 July.[77] A letter, written soon after, is unfortunately bereft not only of the addressee's name but also the date of writing. From later correspondence it may be inferred that he was one P.R. Meenakshisundaram Mudaliar, a lawyer based in Tirunelveli. In it Meenakshi is requesting him to send a *vakalat* to the prison superintendent of Cannanore Jail for VOC's signature.[78] Evidently, VOC had bought time to respond to the court order.

A month later, on 8 July, Meenakshi was writing, presumably to the same lawyer, asking him to draft a statement incorporating the following points, as VOC, a prisoner, was not able to do so himself. Firstly, conceding that he did owe the company money, VOC pleaded that he could not recall the exact amount as more than four years had passed since the transactions took place. Further, as a prisoner, he had no access to any records or files. However, he pointed out a resolution passed by the directors in January 1908 that no interest could be charged on outstanding dues. Secondly, when his resignation was obtained, the directors had assured him that all dues would be written-off. In any case, such dues would also have been barred by limitation. These attenuating circumstances notwithstanding, he assured the court that he was willing to settle all dues within two years of his release from prison. Meenakshi helpfully added that the lawyer could suitably revise these points when submitting the plea in court.[79]

A few weeks later, Meenakshi was writing to the lawyer inquiring if he had received the signed *vakalat*, and if VOC had sent him any further instructions. If he had, could he kindly send her copies as well? One can barely imagine the difficulties that Meenakshi would have been undergoing: